

penny-ante deals. He scratched to pay bills. But he was content, raising five kids and spending weekends with his family aboard a small cabin cruiser.

When he was 42 years old he did his first big deal. It almost ruined him. But next time around he hit a home run. It led to another and then another. By the time he was 50 he had more money than snake-oil salesmen have promises.

Big Bill says he changed after he got power and money. At work he became uptight and suspicious. He drove himself, always riveted on bigger and better deals. He began screaming at servants. He drank more, and after the third drink he started bragging.

Big Bill decided he didn't like his changed self. At age 50 he decided to hang 'em up and spend some of his millions. He bought a sixty-five-foot yacht and headed for Mexico and the Caribbean. He has plans to cross the Atlantic and spend three years in the Mediterranean.

Big Bill is a new man. He's playful and quick to laugh. He radiates goodwill and excitement about the future. "I've learned to enjoy life again," Big Bill told me one afternoon. We were in a peaceful bay in Curaçao, swilling martinis on the yacht's upper deck. "I fix things around the boat. I've always enjoyed doing that, but never had the time. I would just complain when someone else did the job badly. Now I do it myself. When we cruise, I take the helm. I go all night if I want to, without worrying whether I'll be fresh enough to fly back to the office the next day. It's wonderful.

"At first I was reluctant to retire because the money was so good. Twenty years ago I worked six months to make ten thousand dollars. Now with just a few phone calls, it seems, I can make millions. But life is more than being rich. Besides, I'm rich already." At this last, a broad smile covers his face.

Big Bill knew when to quit. His partners, by contrast, seem to be afraid to quit. They made the same deals as Big Bill, and they are all as rich as he is. But they continue to grind.